Nonverbal communication across language barriers

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How does the television program *Pingu* utilize nonverbal communication in order to tell a story which can be understood by a global audience?

In an increasingly globalized and internationalized world, there are more and more situations in which people who lack a shared language find themselves in a situation where communication is necessary. As in these situations, verbal communication (communication utilizing spoken, written, or signed language) would be impossible due to the aforementioned language barrier, nonverbal communication, such as the usage of gestures, is often used as an alternative.

Such methods of communication provide a possibility for communication between groups and individuals who would otherwise be unable to communicate with one another, which allows for the involved individuals to share their stories and perspectives with one another. This improved method of communication allows for new interactions between individuals who otherwise would not have been able to communicate with one another.

Without such communication, it would be much more difficult to understand the perspectives, ideas, and stories of others, which would make it more difficult to properly design fair and just global systems which properly account for the wants, desires, beliefs, and needs of different groups. The lack of communication between groups would lead to an inability for different groups to understand the perspectives of each other, which would pose a problem when developments of new global issues would require cooperation and understanding of one another in order to find a globally suitable solution.

Such nonverbal communication can occur on a large scale with a large audience, such as through the creation of media, such as art, films, or television programs which can communicate without relying on language. Such nonverbal communication would be able to provide a medium through which individuals from different cultures can understand the stories of others, in order to develop a more global understanding of the perspectives and stories of different cultures.

The specific manifestation to be explored is the children's television program *Pingu*, which began airing in Switzerland in 1990. *Pingu*, created by Omar Guttmann and Erika Brueggemann, features no written or spoken language, and instead utilizes nonverbal forms of communication in order to tell a story to the audience. This allowed for the text to develop a global audience, the reach of which was not limited by a requirement for the audience to understand the language of the authors, as the audience could instead understand the story being told through other means of communication. The television program was globally successful, being broadcasted on television channels across the entire world, and developing an international audience who were able to understand the story being told by the authors.

The goal of this essay is to explore **how the television show *Pingu* uses nonverbal communication in order to tell a story to a global audience**. This exploration shall provide information on the different factors and methods through which Guttmann and Brueggemann were successfully able to utilize nonverbal forms of communication in order to create *Pingu*. This knowledge of how nonverbal communication is utilized can provide information on how further communication between otherwise separate groups is possible.

This essay shall first approach this question from the framework of literary analysis (Lang & Lit). This shall allow for an understanding how the different elements that make up *Pingu* are able to work together to tell a story, which shall allow for a better understanding of how different nonverbal elements of communication can be utilized to communicate the same message that would in other circumstances be communicated verbally.

The essay shall then explore to what extent cultural factors could have affected the ability of Guttmann and Brueggemann to communicate a story to the audience. This is important to know as culture often has an impact on how messages are communicated and understood, especially between individuals from different cultures.

This shall be done through an exploration into the extent to which nonverbal communication can be considered universal across cultures, through the framework of Social & Cultural Anthropology.

These methodologies shall then be combined in an interdisciplinary analysis of the extent to which cultural factors could have affected the success of the nonverbal communication utilized by Guttmann and Brueggemann.

This section, combining the understanding of how *Pingu* utilizes nonverbal methods communication, as well as the understanding of to what extent nonverbal communication is a cross-culturally form of understood, shall allow for a more complete understanding of how Guttmann and Brueggemann were able to utilize nonverbal communication in *Pingu* in order to tell a story to an audience of people from different cultures who spoke different languages.

Only through this interdisciplinary method of analysis can an understanding of how nonverbal communication is used effectively be determined, as either a purely literary or anthropological investigation of the topic would be unable to fully grasp how stories are communicated across cultures.

Lang & Lit

Pingu is a Swiss children's television program, created by Omar Guttmann and Erika Brueggemann, which began airing in 1990. The program consists of five-minute-long episodes of stop-motion animation which tells the stories of the titular character Pingu, an anthropomorphic penguin.

The television program developed a global audience, being broadcast in many countries around the world such as in Japan, Canada, India, the United Kingdom, France, and Finland[11], to audiences which often did not share a language with the creators.
This success in communication was in part due to the nonverbal nature of their television program. The authors Omar Guttmann and Erika Brueggemann created the text without utilizing any written, spoken, or signed language to create meaning. Instead, the authors utilized non-linguistic **modes of communication**, such as the auditory, gestural, and visual mode, in order to tell the stories of the characters of *Pingu*.

The terms nonverbal communication and non-linguistic mode of communication have similar meanings. One is a term used in literary analysis to describe how texts communicate meaning without utilizing written or spoken words, while the other is a term used in anthropological research to refer to communication between people, principally in the domain of gestures and body language. While both concepts are extremely similar, there are still certain differences between the two concepts, which are to be explored in greater depth during later sections of the essay.

The term mode of communication refers to the manners in which authors communicate meaning through the creation of a text, and to how audiences create meaning through their consumption of a text. The 5 modes of communication through which the storytelling of *Pingu* shall be explored are as follows:

- The linguistic mode (the transmission of written or spoken words)
- The visual mode (the images and characters that the audience sees)
- Aural mode (transmission of information through sounds)
- Spatial mode (arrangement of elements of a text in relation to each other)
- Gestural mode (the transmission of information through gestures)

The creators of *Pingu* utilized the visual mode, the aural mode, the gestural mode, and the spatial mode to transmit information that would have, in other texts, been transmitted through the linguistic mode.

A scene shall now be analyzed in order to demonstrate how various non-linguistic modes of communication are used in conjunction with one another in order to tell a story in *Pingu*.



These are two screenshots from a scene in Season 1, Episode 3 of *Pingu*, titled *The New Arrival*.

In this scene, the main character Pingu is shown to be overwhelmed by two tasks which he is required to complete, namely to remove the “whistling” teakettle as well as to answer the “ringing” rotary phone. Through context, it is shown that there is a stress placed on Pingu to resolve both tasks in a timely manner. Unfortunately, instead of Pingu being able to complete both tasks, he is too overwhelmed by the tasks ahead of him, and is therefore unable to complete either task, and begins to cry.

This is transmitted through the usage of non-linguistic modes of communication.

The visual mode transmits to the audience that Pingu is crying, by featuring exaggerated tears running down the face of the character, while the gestural mode transmits the actions of the character Pingu.

He is shown with his eyes covered by his hands/flippers and his body hunched over, in a gesture that the audience interprets as Pingu crying due to the stress the character finds himself in. This action is recognized by the audience, who understand that Pingu is overwhelmed and has broken down crying, without the usage of the linguistic mode of communication.

The message that is being conveyed is further reinforced through the usage of the aural mode. The audience hears sounds of “sobbing", and the audience understands that these sounds are coming from the character Pingu. This is both because the audience knows that in this scene, Pingu is crying, as well as due to the audience recognizing that the voice of the crying belongs to the character Pingu.

Despite *Pingu* featuring no verbal language, the characters in the text often “speak” using an incomprehensible gibberish language. While the audience can deduce nothing from the “words” spoken by the characters, the audience still derives meaning from the paralinguistic traits found in the sounds of the characters, such as the pitch and intonation of the sounds.
In this scene, the audience of *Pingu* recognizes the paralinguistic features of the voice of the character, from which the audience understands that the character Pingu is crying.

This message is even further reinforced by the spatial arrangement of the elements of the scene, namely the positioning of the character Pingu between the kettle and the rotary phone.

In this scene, the character is placed between the two tasks he is required to perform, and as the character approaches one of the two tasks, he moves further further from the other. This emphasizes the fact that the completion of both tasks feels impossible to the character, as trying to complete one of the tasks would make it more difficult to complete the other task.

Through the usage of multiple modes of communication, Omar Guttmann and Erika Brueggemann are able to transmit the events of this scene without the linguistic mode of communication. This method of storytelling, in which various nonverbal modes of communication are used in conjunction with one another in order to tell the story of the text, is how the story of *Pingu* is told by the authors to a global audience.

Social & Cultural Anthropology

The Social & Cultural Anthropology section shall explore to what extent certain forms of nonverbal communication can be considered universal, and which factors would have caused this extent of universality. The section primarily focuses on the subset of nonverbal communication known as *kinesics*, the study of body movements and gestures[10], in order to determine to what extent such a form of communication can be considered universal across cultures. This is of importance, as gestures are often utilized in *Pingu*, and the extent to which such gestures are universally understood would have an impact on how *Pingu* is able to tell a story to an audience which does not share certain cultural knowledge.

For facial expressions, there is evidence that both supports and refutes the universality of certain facial expressions across cultures.

Paul Ekman's ethnographic research demonstrated that individuals from many cultures around the world, including one culturally isolated culture from Papua New Guinea, associated facial expressions to similar emotions around the world with fairly high consistency[1]. The fact that these facial expressions were both performed and interpreted similarly by members of completely different cultures suggests that there could be some level of consistency to the significance of facial expressions.[1]

There is also competing research which suggests that the comprehension of facial expressions is culture-specific. Jack et al's research into the universality of the interpretation of facial expressions across cultures demonstrated that culture had an impact on how individuals interpret facial expressions to represent certain emotions.[2]

On the topic of emblems (gestures with very specific meanings), most evidence states that the understandings of emblems are largely culture-specific. Matsumoto et al.'s research[9]

demonstrated many large differences between emblems used across cultures, both with cultures utilizing different emblems to represent similar messages, and with different cultures utilizing similar emblems to describe different thoughts. However, the same research also demonstrated that there are certain emblems that appear to be recognized across all regions of the world, such as the gestures for “stop” and “cigarette”, which were interpreted similarly across cultures[9]

The consideration of gestures being either “universal” or “culture-specific” presents a limiting binary option, with either choice requiring one to dismiss evidence which argues for the other option. Therefore, a change in framework is required, in order to be able to reconcile the fact that there is evidence of both cross-culturally understood and culture-specific examples of nonverbal communication.

The anthropological concept of acculturation can allow insight into how certain cultural understanding of gestures could have come to be shared across cultures, while other gestures would only be understood by members of a more specific culture. Acculturation is a concept in anthropology that, according to anthropologist Alfred Kroeber[4], refers to the process through which cultural items such as ideas, customs, religions, or as is important to this essay, gestures, from different cultures are exchanged through contact between cultures.

These exchanges can occur both directly[3], through interactions between cultures in geographic proximity to one another in which individuals from different cultures exchange knowledge of the meanings of certain elements of nonverbal communication, as well as indirectly, whether

through the development of new transportation technologies allowing for such exchanges to occur between geographically distant cultures [9], or through new globally accessible mediums of communication, such as through the global audiences of television and the internet which allow for exchanges to occur without physical proximity between the individuals involved.[8, 9]
The concept of acculturation can be used to explain how such cultural knowledge would have been exchanged between cultures and individuals, and how a cross-cultural understanding of the significance of certain elements of nonverbal communication would have come to exist.

This framework offers an explanation to why certain gestures, while not carrying a universal meaning across all of human society, can still be understood across certain cultures to carry the same meaning. Examples of this cross-cultural form of understanding is found in the ethnographic interviews of Dane Archer's *A World of Gestures*[5]. In separate videotaped interviews, individuals from both Portuguese and French cultures, when prompted to demonstrate an obscene gesture from their culture, produced the same gesture, in which an arm is held in an L-shape with fist held upwards, and the other hand placed on the first arm's bicep.[5]

The cross-cultural understanding of this gesture would, according to acculturation theory, be due to the cultural exchange of the knowledge of the gesture's meaning. As the two interviewees originated from two countries in geographical proximity, large amounts of cultural exchange between the interviewees' cultures could have easily occurred, from which both individuals would have developed the same understanding of the gesture.

As this evidence demonstrates, there are relatively few if any, truly universal forms of nonverbal communication across all cultures. Gestures can have radically different meanings across cultures, despite being transmitted through identical physical motions, such as the interpretation of the “thumbs up” gesture in American versus Iranian culture. While individuals with American cultural knowledge would interpret this as a friendly gesture signifying good luck, people with Iranian cultural knowledge could instead interpret this gesture to have a vulgar and expletive meaning.[6]

Even facial expressions, which demonstrated some consistency in how they are utilized and interpreted across cultures compared to gestures, also have different rules across cultures which govern the messages they transmit.[7]

Despite the comprehension of nonverbal communication not being universal across cultures, there also appear to be many situations where certain cultures share a similar understanding of the significance of certain gestures.

This shared cultural knowledge, according to acculturation theory, could have come about due to interactions between cultures in which the involved cultures would have exchanged understandings of their forms of nonverbal communication.

Interdisciplinary Analysis of *Pingu*

The television program *Pingu* has a global audience, with the show being broadcasted in diverse countries with different cultures. The text utilizes nonverbal communication in order to tell its story, which allows it to be understood by an audience which does not necessarily share a language with the creators of the text. While the prior section of the paper determined that there are relatively few forms of nonverbal communication that are truly universal across all human cultures, it was also able to utilize acculturation theory to explain how comprehension of certain forms of nonverbal communication could have been similar between certain cultures. According to acculturation theory, the cross-cultural understanding of the significance of certain forms of nonverbal communication could have come to exist through both direct and indirect exchange between individuals from different cultures.

It is important to note that in this anthropological section of this essay, the term nonverbal communication was principally used in reference to the different forms of face-to-face interpersonal communication used by people. This somewhat differs from how the similar concept of “nonlinguistic modes of communication” was utilized in the English section of this essay, in which the concept referred to nonlinguistic communication of meaning through a text. The anthropological exploration of nonverbal communication is mainly relevant to the understanding of the **gestural** mode of communication, which is one of the many forms of non linguistic modes of communication used in text *Pingu*. The concept of nonlinguistic modes of communication includes other aspects of communication as well, such as that which is done through visual storytelling, communication through spatial arrangement of elements of a text, and through different auditory elements such as tone of voice, as well as sound effects.

Omar Guttmann and Erika Brueggemann, in their creation of *Pingu*, created a text which could be understood by audiences who did not necessarily speak the same language or originate from the same culture as the creators.

Pingu was able to tell its story through the usage of multimodal methods of communication, by communicating the events of the show through a combination of the usage of visual imagery, sound, gestures, and spatial arrangement of elements of the show, which enabled the audience to not need to speak the same language or belong to the same culture as its creators.

Sometimes, the audience would have understood the meanings of the gestures utilized in *Pingu*, due to the cross-cultural knowledge of the meanings of certain well-known gestures existing, according to acculturation theory, due to both direct and indirect cultural exchanges of knowledge.
However, even in situations where the audience did not understand the meaning transmitted through the gestural mode, the multimodal nature of *Pingu* allows the audience to have an understanding of the story, even if certain individual elements of the text, such as a culture-specific gesture, are not necessarily understood.

Consider the scene of *Pingu* analyzed in the earlier section of this essay, in which the character Pingu is overwhelmed by the two tasks ahead of him. In the creation of this scene, Guttmann and Brueggemann utilized all of the relevant methods of communication in order to clearly communicate the events of the scene to the audience. The knowledge that the character Pingu is crying due to feeling overwhelmed is transmitted to the audience through a combination of the visual, gestural, auditory, and spatial modes of communication. Even if the audience were

wholly unaware of the character's gesture signifying that the character was crying, the audience would still be able to understand that the character was feeling overwhelmed, and crying, due to such feelings through the other modes of communication being utilized. As both the visual mode, depicting the tears of the characters, and the aural mode, transmitting the "crying" sounds of the character, were both transmitting the same information that the gesture is transmitting, even if the crying gesture was not understood by the audience, the other modes of communication still clearly communicated the emotional state of this scene and would have allowed the audience to understand the story of the show.

This is how *Pingu* communicates effectively to the audience who may not understand every single element of the text due to differences in cultural knowledge. As Guttmann and Brueggemann told the story of the text through the usage of multiple modes of communication, all being used to transmit the same message, even if the audience is unable to understand one of the particular element of the text, such as one of the gestures utilized, the meaning transmitted in the scene would still be able to be understood through the other modes of communication utilized.

This method of communication, in which the various modes of communication function to create a consistent, cohesive meaning is how *Pingu* is able to create meaning for audiences from diverse cultures who may often have different cultural understandings of certain elements of the text, such as the gestures included.

Conclusion

The interdisciplinary analysis of how nonverbal communication is utilized in *Pingu* provided insight into how Guttman and Brueggemann were able to create a cross-culturally understood text by utilizing multiple modes of communication in order to tell a story.

The investigation revealed that the way in which the different modes of communication were used in accordance with one another in *Pingu*, namely in the way that the different modes were utilized together in a consistent manner to transmit similar information, allowed for the audience of *Pingu* to understand the story that was being told. Even if the audience lacked the understanding of the message transmitted by certain gestures, due to the particular gesture utilized by Guttmann and Brueggemann not being known by the audience, the audience could still understand the story being told in *Pingu*. During these situations in which the gestural mode proved ineffective at communicating, the story of the text was instead communicated to the audience through the other modes of the text, such as through the visual and aural modes of communication.

One surprising finding, discovered during the anthropological section of this essay, was the level of variation among how certain gestures were understood across cultures.

The initial assumption was that, as the television show *Pingu* was understood across cultures, that the underlying methods of communication that were utilized, namely gestures, would also therefore have been understood the same way across cultures. The findings of the anthropological research into the topic demonstrated that the truth was quite far from the initial assumption, that there were instead large differences in the ways that different cultures

interpreted gestures. Further anthropological research could be done with the goal of conclusively determining if there do exist any truly universal forms of communication, as well as into determining the reasons why certain gestures would have developed their connotations.

The anthropological theory of acculturation could be of further use in investigating the factors which allowed for certain cultures to share understandings of gestures. One example of this could be to utilize ethnographic data on gestures, in combination with historical knowledge of the interactions between cultures in order to attempt to trace the lineages of particular gestures to the points from which they originated.

Furthermore, research could be done into the topic of determining the role of media, such as *Pingu* itself, in the spreading of such cultural knowledge. This further research could provide insight into the extent to which the gestural communication in *Pingu* could function as an example of “cultural exchange” through which audiences could have developed a better understanding of the same gestures utilized by Guttmann and Brueggemann, and if this newfound knowledge of gestures could potentially allow for future communication to utilize the newly cross-culturally understood examples of gestures created through the influence of *Pingu*.

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